

Comfort zone: "I am very comfortable at this kind of club, where the facilities are very good. I would indeed like to have more Goan players on the main team, and let's see if we can do it in the future," said Manolo while talking about FC Goa. FOCUSSPORTS/ISL

2022 World Cup]. In 2002, South Korea finished fourth because they put the national team together in a camp for six months before the World Cup with a lot of strong games.

And India has to start one day. I know people talk about development, but they are more worried about organisation than development. I think development is more important. Of course, you need kids, but you also need coaches who know what they have to explain to the kids at every moment. You have to show up at every moment across ages six, nine, and 14.

We can speak about a lot of things, like the World Cup and the Asian Cup, but the problem is not these competitions. The problem is that you still don't have the correct structure to arrive at this level.

Stimac spoke about wanting more time in training ahead of the Asian Cup. Otherwise, he can't take responsibility for the results. How do you view his situation?

The organisation in India is something that can be improved. For example, on January 22, we play Odisha in the Super Cup, but after that, we don't know when our next game will be. If we win, we play [the knockouts] on the 25th.

I completely understand Igor Stimac. If I am the national team coach, I would like more time. I am sure Igor completely understands that the ISL coaches want to have the players for the maximum time possible. We need to know, for example, when the 2024-25 season starts and how the season is structured as to when the Durand Cup, ISL, and Super Cup are scheduled. But I understand things in



India don't work this way because, at the last moment, some teams will say they cannot play the competition.

For example, in the Durand Cup, Army teams and some teams from the I-League cannot play in the competition. It's a similar case with the Super Cup, and finally only five teams from the I-League decided to play this year.

If you don't have the right planning, it's difficult for the national team coach and ISL coaches to know when we have the second leg of the ISL matches. But obviously, people are interested in other things.

Will the ISL benefit from moving to a Conference system like the USA?

I prefer to play all the teams in the country as we do now. Yes, the distance is big. If you are in Goa or Hyderabad, you are more or less close to every team in the country. But if we have to go from Goa to Jamshedpur through Ranchi and take a three-hour bus ride, it is difficult. Or you have to go to Kolkata and then take a train to Jamshedpur, which is difficult. I prefer this to half-and-half. India needs more teams. One competition with 12 teams is not enough.

I worked in Croatia, which is a very small country. There are 10 teams, but you play four rounds. You have to travel to Zagreb eight times, which can be boring. Here, the flights are long, but you can go two days before. But this is not the problem; it is about how to organise in every state.

There are states where football is very good, but in some states, it isn't. I will give you an anecdote. Two days after we were the champions of the ISL with Hyderabad FC, I was wearing a polo shirt with the logo of the club. One person asked me what the logo was, and I said 'Hyderabad FC', and they replied, 'But which sport?'

And it made me realise that India is very big, and there should be space not only for cricket. I think there would have to be space for more sports in India.